

FREE WHITE PAPER

Switching from Paper Without Losing a Day

A step-by-step plan to move your shop onto software in two weeks, with your customers, your balances and your sanity intact.

For independent auto repair shops with ten technicians or fewer.

XSite Auto xsiteauto.com

BEFORE YOU START

The switch is easier than it looks.

Most owners who stay on paper aren't against software. They're worried about the switch: losing customers or balances, a week of chaos at the counter, or a team that won't use it. Those worries are reasonable, and every one of them can be planned around.

This white paper is a plan for moving a small shop off paper and spreadsheets in about two weeks, without closing for a day. It works for any shop software. Each step has a goal, what to do and the common mistakes. At the back you'll find a day-by-day timeline, a switch-day checklist, and what to tell your customers.

01 **Decide what comes over**
Day 1

02 **Export your customer list**
Day 1

03 **Clean the list**
Day 2

04 **Set up the basics**
Days 3 to 5

05 **Import and check**
Day 5

06 **Pick your switch day**
Week 2

07 **Run both for a week**
Week 2

08 **Train the team**
Week 2

09 **Turn on the customer side**
Week 3

10 **Review and retire paper**
End of month 1

Rather not do it yourself?

With XSite Auto's done-for-you setup, our team does steps 1 to 5 for you and trains your staff, so you can start on step 6.

STEP 1 OF 10 · DAY 1

Decide what comes over

The biggest mistake in a switch is trying to move everything. Years of old invoices don't need to be in the new system on day one. Your active customers, their vehicles and what they owe you do.

Goal: Bring over what you use every week, and leave the rest where it is.

WHAT TO DO

1. Bring over customers you've seen in the last two or three years, with phone, email and address.
2. Bring over open balances, so nothing owed is lost.
3. Leave old job history in QuickBooks or your files, where you can still look it up.
4. Write down the services and prices you use most. You'll set those up next.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Spending weeks cleaning up ten years of history before starting.

> **In XSite Auto:** Customers and balances come over from a QuickBooks export in minutes.

STEP 2 OF 10 · DAY 1

Export your customer list

If you use QuickBooks, your customer list is already there. Getting it out as a spreadsheet takes a few minutes.

Goal: One spreadsheet with your active customers, ready to import.

WHAT TO DO

1. Export your customer list from QuickBooks to Excel or CSV, including name, phone, email, address and open balance.
2. If you're not sure how, your bookkeeper can do it in a few minutes, or we can walk you through it.
3. Save a copy somewhere safe before you change anything. It's your backup.
4. If you keep customers on paper or in another program, a simple spreadsheet with the same columns works too.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Editing the only copy of your export.

> **In XSite Auto:** Upload the CSV or Excel file QuickBooks exports, as it is. Our team can also do the export and import for you.

STEP 3 OF 10 · DAY 2

Clean the list

Half an hour of tidying now saves months of confusion later. The new system is only as good as the list you put in it.

Goal: No duplicates, phone numbers that work, and only customers you'd actually call.

WHAT TO DO

1. Remove duplicates, such as the same person entered twice with slightly different spellings.
2. Fix phone numbers so each has all ten digits.
3. Remove customers you haven't seen in years and don't expect to.
4. Check the open balances against what you believe is owed.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Skipping the clean-up and fixing duplicates one by one for months.

> **In XSite Auto:** The import skips customers marked inactive in QuickBooks and matches people who are already in the system, so you don't get doubles.

STEP 4 OF 10 · DAYS 3 TO 5

Set up the basics

A new system feels awkward when every job needs something set up first. Getting the basics in before you start means day one feels normal.

Goal: Your rates, tax, technicians, hours and common services are in before the first real job.

WHAT TO DO

1. Enter your labour rate, shop supplies and tax settings.
2. Add your technicians and the hours each one works.
3. Add your business hours and the services you offer most, with prices.
4. Create logins for everyone who'll use it, and decide who can do what.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Starting with real customers before rates and tax are set, then fixing invoices.

> **In XSite Auto:** Done-for-you setup covers all of this: rates, tax, technicians, your QuickBooks import, booking on your website and Google, and an hour of training.

STEP 5 OF 10 · DAY 5

Import and check

The import itself takes minutes. The important part is the five minutes afterwards, checking that what came in is right.

Goal: Your customers are in, and you've checked a handful by hand.

WHAT TO DO

1. Import the cleaned list.
2. Look up five customers you know well. Check names, phone numbers and balances.
3. Check the total of open balances matches your QuickBooks report.
4. If something's wrong, fix the spreadsheet and import again rather than fixing records one at a time.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Assuming the import was perfect without looking.

> **In XSite Auto:** Before anything is saved, a preview shows how many customers are new, which match ones you already have, and which will be skipped. If something looks wrong, you can undo the import.

STEP 6 OF 10 · WEEK 2

Pick your switch day

When you start matters. The first day on any new system is slower. Pick a day that can absorb that.

Goal: Start on a day when you have room to learn, not your busiest.

WHAT TO DO

1. Choose a normally quiet day. For many shops that's midweek, not Monday morning.
2. Book a little lighter that day, so there's time to learn.
3. Have everyone log in and try booking a job the day before.
4. Make one person the go-to for questions on the day.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Switching during the tire rush or the week before a holiday.

STEP 7 OF 10 · WEEK 2

Run both for a week

For the first week, keep your old way going quietly in the background. If something goes wrong, nothing is lost, and the team relaxes because they know there's a backup.

Goal: A safety net while everyone builds confidence.

WHAT TO DO

1. Write every new job into the new system first.
2. Keep the paper schedule or old system up to date as a backup for the first few days.
3. At each day's close, compare the two. They should match.
4. Once three days in a row match without problems, stop the backup.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Running both systems for months because nobody decides to stop.

STEP 8 OF 10 · WEEK 2

Train the team

People don't need to learn everything. They need to learn the five things they do every day, and know who to ask about the rest.

Goal: Everyone can do their part of the day in the new system.

WHAT TO DO

1. Fifteen minutes with each person on just the tasks they do: booking, writing up a job, moving it on the board, taking a payment.
2. Show technicians how to see their day and update a job from a phone.
3. Put a one-page cheat sheet by the counter.
4. Ask for feedback at the end of the first week, and fix the annoyances.

COMMON MISTAKE

- One long training session on every feature, which nobody remembers.

> **In XSite Auto:** A one-hour training session for your team comes with done-for-you setup, and the Help page in the app walks through setup and what every tab and button does.

STEP 9 OF 10 · WEEK 3

Turn on the customer side

Once the shop is running smoothly on the new system, turn on the parts customers see. That way, the first online booking arrives at a shop that's ready for it.

Goal: **Customers can book online and check themselves in, once the team is comfortable.**

WHAT TO DO

1. Add the booking link to your website, Google listing and Facebook.
2. Put the check-in QR code on the counter.
3. Change your voicemail to mention online booking.
4. Tell regular customers they can now book online any time.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Launching online booking on day one, while the team is still learning.

> **In XSite Auto:** Your booking page, check-in QR code and website are ready as soon as you are.

STEP 10 OF 10 · END OF MONTH 1

Review and retire paper

After a month, take stock. It's the moment to drop the last bits of paper and to see what the switch has changed.

Goal: **The old way is gone, and you know what's better.**

WHAT TO DO

1. Remove the paper schedule and old forms so nobody falls back on them.
2. Look at what's changed: missed calls, unbilled work, balances owing, time spent at the close.
3. Ask the team what still feels slow, and fix it.
4. Keep your QuickBooks export somewhere safe as a record.

COMMON MISTAKE

- Keeping the paper "just in case" until it becomes the real system again.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

The two-week timeline

A plan for a typical small shop. Stretch it if you're busy. What matters is the order.

Day 1	**Decide and export**	Choose what comes over. Export your customer list and open balances from QuickBooks.
Day 2	**Clean the list**	Remove duplicates, fix phone numbers, drop customers you won't see again.
Days 3 to 5	**Set up the basics**	Rates, tax, technicians, hours, services and logins.
Day 5	**Import and check**	Import the list and check five customers and the balance total.
Day 6	**Practice**	Everyone logs in and books a pretend job.
Day 8	**Switch day**	A quieter day, booked a little lighter, with one go-to person.
Days 8 to 12	**Run both**	New system first, paper as backup. Compare at each close.
Day 12	**Stop the backup**	Three matching days in a row, and the paper schedule retires.
Week 3	**Customer side**	Booking link on your website and Google, check-in QR code on the counter.
End of month	**Review**	What's better, what's still slow, and what to fix next.

PRINTABLE

Switch-day checklist

Go through this the day before you switch. Date: _____

- [ ] Customer list imported and five customers checked by hand
- [ ] Open balances total matches QuickBooks
  QuickBooks total $_____ New system total $_____
- [ ] Labour rate, shop supplies and tax set up
- [ ] Technicians and their hours entered
- [ ] Common services and prices entered
- [ ] Everyone has a login and has booked a practice job
- [ ] Tomorrow's appointments entered in the new system
- [ ] Paper schedule kept as backup for the first few days
- [ ] Go-to person for questions:
  _____
- [ ] Cheat sheet printed and by the counter
- [ ] Switch day booked a little lighter than usual

What to tell your customers

Counter sign

We've upgraded our system to serve you faster. Thanks for your patience this week. You can now book online any time at [web address].

Message to regular customers (week 3)

Hi [name], good news from [shop]: you can now book your next service online, any time of day, at [link]. Same team, same service, just easier.

Switch with a hand to hold

Start a free 14-day trial and follow this plan with your own customers, or let our team do the setup, import your QuickBooks customers and train your staff, so you start at step 6.

$99 USD or $139 CAD a month after a free 14-day trial, with no credit card needed and no contract. Done-for-you setup is optional ($495 USD or $695 CAD, one time).

Start a free trial **Book a 15-minute demo**

XSite Auto is a product of XSite Group Inc., Unit 5 - 165 Highway 20 W., Fonthill, ON L0S 1E5 · 905.346.0864 · david@xsitegroup.ca · xsiteauto.com · Serving owner-run businesses since 2011.